

Rajendralal Mitra

INDIA'S FORGOTTEN PIONEER OF
YOGA SUTRA SCHOLARSHIP

CHAPTER 5

It was not until twenty-nine years after Colebrooke's groundbreaking study that James Ballantyne brought out the earliest partial English translation of the *Yoga Sutra*, in 1852. Ballantyne's unfinished translation of the *Yoga Sutra* would not be completed until 1871, when a pandit named Govinda Shastri Deva translated its final two chapters—"in a disjointed way" according to Rajendralal Mitra—in successive issues of a Varanasi review titled "The Pandit." However, the complete Ballantyne–Shastri Deva translation did not appear in a single bound volume until two years after the publication of Mitra's own 1883 translation. Like the Ballantyne–Shastri Deva collaboration, Mitra's translation of the *Yoga Sutra* included Bhoja's commentary. All resemblance between the two ends here, however, as Mitra's work far outshines not only that of Ballantyne–Shastri Deva but also the majority of translations that have been attempted since. Largely overlooked in both academic and popular circles, Mi-

† tra's is an important work of erudition and an essential chapter in the history of critical Yoga scholarship. His extensive hundred-page preface and incisive commentary were an exponential advance over Colebrooke's brief overview of 1823, making his the first scholarly volume entirely dedicated to an excavation of the *Yoga Sutra*. Here one finds, among many other things, the earliest comprehensive investigation into the "historical" Patanjali and the relationship between the author of the *Yoga Sutra* and the other Patanjalis of the Indian history of ideas. In spite of its importance, Mitra's contribution is conspicuously absent from nearly every historical survey, which leap from Colebrooke's study to lesser overviews by Richard Garbe (1896) and Max Müller (1899). Published in the prestigious "Bibliotheca Indica" series, it has long been out of print, with only a handful of copies extant, which perhaps accounts for its neglect.

In the summer of 2011, I was able to procure a microfilm copy of Mitra's work through the University of California's interlibrary loan system. What I read came as a revelation of sorts. As we saw in chapter 2, the philosophical system of the *Yoga Sutra*—that is, the bulk of the text, leaving aside its instructions on the eight-part practice—is not simple. No doubt for this reason a small army of critical scholars, yoga gurus, and yoga enthusiasts of every stripe has for the past century been churning out volumes of printed page attempting to explicate the subtleties of that system. In doing so, nearly all have adhered to the format of commentarial

convention, slavishly following the order of the sutras as they are found in the original text. However, as Ram Shankar Bhattacharya (who coedited the massive and authoritative “encyclopedia” of Yoga together with Gerald James Larson) has observed, Patanjali’s original ordering cannot but confuse the modern mind: “the arrangement is not at all helpful to persons of modern times in understanding the doctrines of yoga in an easier way.”¹ S. Radhakrishnan is less charitable: for him Patanjali’s system is fundamentally incoherent. In other words, by following the order of the sutras, one loses the forest for the trees. Over the past century, several metaphorical forests have been lost in this way. Because much of this book is devoted to the ways in which people have interpreted Patanjali’s system, I find it useful to reproduce Mitra’s summary of its fundamental axioms, which he presents with a succinctness and clarity I have not found elsewhere.

What follows is taken nearly verbatim from Mitra. I have, however, edited some of his quaint nineteenth-century expressions, replacing them with their modern synonyms, which are indicated in square brackets. A term that frequently appears in Mitra’s summary is “noumenon,” a term he explicitly borrows from Kantian philosophy, to refer to a “thing-in-itself,” that is, an object directly apprehended by the mind or intellect, and not by the senses (in which case it is called a “phenomenon”). This is Mitra’s translation of the Sanskrit word *tattva*, which I translated in chapter 2 as “entity,” “principle,” or “substrate.” Mitra also translates

Purusha as “soul” rather than “Person” or “Spirit,” and I have retained his usage here. Mitra divides his exposition into seventeen sequenced points. One only wishes that Patanjali had presented his system in the same way, since it would have made the *Yoga Sutra* far more accessible:

- 1st. That there is a Supreme Godhead (Ishvara) who is purely spiritual, or all soul, perfectly free from afflictions, works, deserts, and desires. His symbol is Om, and He rewards those who are ardently devoted to Him by facilitating their attainment of liberation; but He does not directly grant it. Nor is He the father, creator, or protector of the universe, with which He is absolutely unconnected.
- 2nd. That there are countless individual souls (*Puru-shas*) that animate living beings and are eternal. They are pure and immutable, but by their association with the universe they become indirectly the experiencers of joys and sorrows and assume innumerable embodied forms in course of ever recurring [reincarnation].
- 3rd. That the universe is uncreate[d] and eternal. It undergoes phenomenal changes, but, as a noumenon, it is always the same. In its noumenal state it is called *Prakriti* or nature; it is always associated with the three qualities or active forces (*gunas*)... Matter as an integral part of the universe is, likewise, eternal, though subject

to modifications like the world. Strictly speaking, the modifications of matter produce the phenomenal world, which is composed of it.

- 4th. That next to the soul there is a noumenon called *citta*, or the thinking principle, or mind in its most comprehensive sense. It is subject to the three qualities aforesaid and undergoes various modifications according to the prevalence of one or other of these qualities. It is essentially unconscious or unintelligent, but it becomes conscious or intelligent by the reflection of, or association with, soul, which abides close by it. It also receives through the organs of sense shadows of external objects, and thereupon modifies itself into the shapes of those objects. The consciousness reflected on it makes it think that it is the experiencer of all worldly joys and sorrows. In reality, however, it is merely the spectacle of which the soul is by proxy (its shadow) the spectator.
- 5th. That the functions of the thinking principle are five-fold, including right notion, misconception, fancy, sleep, and memory, and that these functions are produced by the prevalence of one or other of the three qualities.
- 6th. That like the universe, all sensible objects have their eternal archetypes or noumena, which undergo phenomenal changes, but are never absolutely destroyed. When one object changes into another, it is merely a modification of its form,

and the form assumed, when destroyed, passes on to some other form, but it ultimately reverts to its noumenal or primary state.

- 7th. That phenomena, as results of modifications of noumena, are real and not phantasmal.
- 8th. That [sense-objects] are not the direct causes of sensations, nor sensations the causes of [sense-objects]; but that the thinking principle receives impressions of [sense-objects] under the influence of one or other of the three qualities, and the result is regulated by that influence. The influence extends both to sensations and to [sense-objects].
- 9th. That the thinking principle being changeable, constancy of knowledge is due to the immutability of the soul, and that no perception can take place until the thinking principle is made conscious by the soul.
- 10th. That impressions produced on the thinking principle leave on it certain [residues] . . . which are the causes of intuitions, desires, new births, and further experience.
- 11th. That desires are the origin of pain in the world.
- 12th. That the universe being eternal, desires are likewise eternal, and it is needless therefore to inquire when [residues] first arose to create desires.
- 13th. That mundane existence is thus associated with pain, and it is the duty of everyone to rise above that pain.

- 14th. That the pain may be finally overcome or removed only by withdrawing the thinking principle from its natural functions.
- 15th. That the withdrawal in question can be effected by constant and sedulous observance of certain prescribed restraints, obligations, and steadfast meditation.
- 16th. That in the course of the exercises above referred to, the adept attains extraordinary occult powers.
- 17th. That when that withdrawal is complete and absolute, the soul is completely isolated from the world, and that when that isolation is attained, it is liberated from all liability to future transmigration. And this is the isolation, liberation, emancipation, or final beatitude, which should be the great object and aim of human existence.²

Mitra's reading of the *Yoga Sutra* is colored throughout by Bhoja's commentary, of which he was highly appreciative. His opinion of Vyasa, whom Bhoja "treated † with withering sarcasm," is quite the opposite, as evidenced in his evaluation of the "Commentary" as "the production of a third class writer."³ I have already noted Mitra's opinion of India's yogis, and his distinction between their delusional vagaries and Yoga philosophy itself. Elsewhere, Mitra expands on the division of labor among scholars, ascetics (whom he distinguishes from yogis), and pandits:

† The subject is dry—exceedingly so—and the enigmatical form in which it is presented in the textbooks is not conducive to any interest being created in its favour. Generally speaking Indian scholars do not study it, and the few ascetics and hermits who do seldom associate with the world. Pandits, when called upon to explain, frequently, if not invariably, mix up the tenets of Patanjali's Yoga with those of the Tantras, the Puranas . . . and the Bhagavad Gita—works which have very dissimilar and discordant tenets to inculcate.⁴

In a Hindu India that was firmly entrenched in (Neo-) Vedanta philosophy, interest in the *Yoga Sutra* did not begin to awaken in intellectual circles until Mitra's pioneering translation. As for the ascetics and hermits evoked here, we see Mitra subscribing to a perennial Indian tradition concerning the Himalayas as a kind of Shangri-la, the pristine haunt of authentic sages in whose entranced minds all of India's ancient wisdom had survived intact. As I mentioned earlier, Mitra had unsuccessfully attempted to find a "professional yogi"

† or pandit to guide him in his translation project—although he does speak of a person in Varanasi who would have apprenticed him, had he, Mitra, been ready to live in his hut and follow in his footsteps to the end of his days. Like Colebrooke before him, Mitra

† relied on his own knowledge of Sanskrit for his translation, but he also acknowledges the aid of two Nyaya

and Samkhya specialists from the Kolkata Sanskrit College, as well as his dependence on Colebrooke's translation of a treatise on Samkhya for his own translations of technical terms.

Most interesting is Mitra's account of India's pandits. As was noted with respect to Colebrooke's "rediscovery" of the *Yoga Sutra*, Yoga philosophy had been effectively dropped from the traditional north Indian brahmanic curriculum by no later than the sixteenth century. With no living link to Patanjali's text and its commentarial tradition, the pandits, when asked, would do what pandits have always done: string together what they knew about Yoga—mainly from the Puranas and Smriti literature, but also from Tantric and Hatha Yoga traditions—and identify that amalgam with the teachings of the *Yoga Sutra*. In any case, as the custodians of Hindu tradition, they would have had no reason to familiarize themselves with a work from which God as they knew it was absent. This is very important, because it continues to be the case with nearly every modern yoga guru, including the illustrious Vivekananda, Krishnamacharya, and Yogi Bikram. The so-called *Yoga Sutra* the gurus have been teaching their Western followers for over a century has been the eight-part practice of the Puranas and various other scraps of yoga lore known to the pandits. It has precious little in common with the philosophical *Yoga Sutra* of Patanjali and his classical commentators. To be sure, every classical commentator beginning with Vyasa did quote from the Puranas, *Bhagavad Gita*, and

other works; however, they referred to them to illustrate points of Yoga philosophy rather than to substitute them for a lack of knowledge of the same.

† Mitra also took a hardheaded approach toward Western philosophers and Indologists whom he saw as playing fast and loose with the content and coherence of the Yoga system. One of these was the German Indologist Albrecht Weber, who, like so many others, had read the *Yoga Sutra* through the lens of Advaita Vedanta. Weber, who identified *kaivalyam*—the final isolation of Spirit from Nature—with “absorption into the supreme Godhead,” was taken to task by Mitra, who suggested that Weber had never read the *Yoga Sutra* but had rather based his interpretation on the *Bhagavad Gita* and Puranic and Tantric modifications of Yoga philosophy. Ditto the French philosopher Victor Cousin, who had defined *kaivalyam* as “absolute nihilism, the final fruit of skepticism.”⁵ Here, Mitra responded by reminding his reader that since Yoga philosophy posits the continuing existence—rather than the annihilation—of the soul after death, the claim of nihilism was unfounded.

† Ever attentive to presenting the philosophy of the *Yoga Sutra* as philosophy, Mitra noted that those aspects of Patanjali’s system that appeared unworthy of philosophical inquiry had their parallels in Western ways of thought. This included the positing of universal categories or noumena, which he compared to those of both the ancient Greek and nineteenth-century Continental philosophers. Noting that “the

two most repellent dogmas of the system are its faith in metempsychosis [i.e., transmigration of the soul] and occult powers,” he allowed that “carefully considered, they do not seem to be so absurd as one would at first glance suppose.”⁶ Concerning transmigration, Mitra, who knew his Classics, pointed to its presence in Plato’s writings. Quoting an English clergyman, he also noted that the Hindu doctrine of karma and rebirth was a more satisfying explanation for theodicy, the problem of evil, than the Christian doctrine of predestination. With respect to the occult powers that are the subject of the *Yoga Sutra*’s third chapter, he compared them to “mesmeric and other conditions of the body [that] are now objects of scientific research.”⁷ In fact, the Magnetic System—also known as Mesmerism in recognition of its founder, the German physician Franz Anton Mesmer—was all the rage during the final decades of the nineteenth century, at which time many considered it to be hard science, as opposed to mere scientism. This was the position taken by a certain Madame Helena Petrovna Blavatsky, whose 1877 occult blockbuster, *Isis Unveiled*, drew heavily upon the theory of animal magnetism and all that went with it.